

Teaching AI as a Learning Partner

A neurodivergent-friendly professional development artifact grounded in my Pine Brook IGNITE teaching placement

Ask

Check

Choose

Change

Core claim

Teachers need explicit routines for helping students use AI without losing voice, judgment, or ownership.

What professional problem am I trying to solve?

Big idea

Teachers are being asked to use AI in classrooms, but many still need a practical, equity-centered structure for doing it well.

What I saw in placement

- ▶ strong curiosity about AI
- ▶ high engagement with digital tools
- ▶ students moving quickly to whatever the tool produced

Why teachers need support

- ▶ tool navigation overshadowing learning
- ▶ copying without checking
- ▶ uneven independence
- ▶ teachers needing a routine they can actually implement

Why this matters in EDU442

- ▶ EDU442 asks us to turn course ideas about race, class, gender, disability, and equity into a usable practice artifact.
- ▶ A professional development module is one valid impacting-practice format under the assignment.
- ▶ In my placement, inclusive teaching often meant balancing **support** with **independence**.
- ▶ That same tension appeared in AI lessons:
 - students needed structure to access the tool
 - but too much teacher rescue reduced agency
- ▶ This project grew into a PD question: **How can we help teachers teach AI in ways that support diverse learners without reproducing inequity or replacing student thinking?**

Placement evidence that shaped the project

Source	What it showed	What I learned
Responsible AI and Canva Publishing	AI literacy needs chunked routines, visible success criteria, and clear proof of learning.	Students need AI instruction that is structured, not vague.
AI as a Thought Partner	Students benefit when AI is framed as a helper for brainstorming and problem solving.	The language around AI matters. It should support thinking, not replace it.
MagicSchool pilot lesson	Students needed modeling for login, prompts, topic choice, and deciding what to keep from AI output.	Responsible AI use must be explicitly taught.

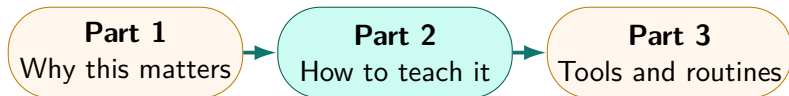
My impacting practice artifact

Artifact

Professional Development Module: Teaching AI as a Learning Partner

- ▶ A teacher-facing PD session built from my MagicSchool Student-Choice AI Partner Project
- ▶ Intended audience: elementary teachers exploring classroom AI use
- ▶ Main deliverable: a practical framework, model lesson structure, and implementation moves
- ▶ The PD does not just say “use AI”
- ▶ It trains teachers to help students **plan, check, revise, explain, and stay the author of their own work**

What the PD module includes



Across all three sessions

Teachers learn a reusable classroom routine: **Ask, Check, Choose, Change, Explain**

What teachers learn in the PD

Instructional design moves

- ▶ chunked directions
- ▶ visible routines
- ▶ reduced typing load
- ▶ prompt starters
- ▶ checkpoints before overload grows

Inclusive implementation moves

- ▶ flexible product choices
- ▶ teacher think-alouds
- ▶ partner roles
- ▶ drawing, dictation, or oral rehearsal before typing
- ▶ support for access without removing ownership

Key principle

The tool should adapt to the learner. The learner should not have to adapt completely to the tool.

Core message of the PD

- ▶ AI can help students brainstorm, narrow a topic, and organize ideas.
- ▶ It can reduce the blank-page problem for students who struggle to get started.
- ▶ It can support clearer explanations, simpler language, and step-by-step planning.
- ▶ For some learners, especially students who need structure or language support, AI can function as a low-stakes thought partner.

But only if...

teachers are prepared to teach questioning, revising, and explaining rather than allowing copy-and-submit use.

What the classroom evidence tells teachers

What teachers should keep

- ▶ student choice increased buy-in
- ▶ copyable prompts reduced friction
- ▶ teacher modeling made safer use possible
- ▶ partner talk lowered language load

What teachers should plan for

- ▶ logging in and tab management took time
- ▶ some students treated AI output as final
- ▶ some topics were too broad
- ▶ success criteria had to remain visible all lesson

The deeper instructional shift

Big idea

This PD is not about giving teachers one more tool. It is about helping teachers shape how students think with AI while keeping authorship, judgment, and responsibility.

- ▶ This is a digital-literacy goal.
- ▶ This is an inclusion goal.
- ▶ This is also a future-ready goal for classrooms where AI will increasingly be present.

Why this counts as impacting practice

- ▶ It is grounded in real teaching-placement experience, not a hypothetical future classroom.
- ▶ It responds to a recurring instructional need I actually observed.
- ▶ It produces a reusable PD artifact that another teacher or team could adapt.
- ▶ It connects educational technology, special education thinking, and responsible instruction.
- ▶ It moves from reflection to design:
 - What did I see?
 - What problem kept repeating?
 - What practical teacher support could improve it?

What I would add to the PD next

- ▶ a facilitator guide with timing and discussion prompts
- ▶ sample student artifacts from each product type
- ▶ a teacher-facing checklist for prompt quality, topic fit, and independence
- ▶ a shorter version for grade-level teams or coaching cycles
- ▶ a lighter adaptation for younger grades or higher-support settings

Closing

Final takeaway

My impacting practice project argues that teachers need PD for AI use that is grounded in visible routines, inclusive scaffolds, and student ownership.

- ▶ AI should be a learning partner, not a shortcut.
- ▶ Teacher support should open access, not replace student thinking.
- ▶ Inclusive structure is what makes responsible AI use possible in real classrooms.